

Dual core netbooks

Intel planning on launching dual core Atom processors for netbooks

Browser benchmarks

After Futuremark, Rightware launches new browser benchmark - Browsermark

HD Player Test

DTH services! All you do is plug in your portable drive and view the content off it.

The HD player market has been bubbling with activity in sync with the TV market since the trend started off. WD was one of the first to enter to market and we received three of their products. We also received a Seagate HD player and two ASUS products. Xstreamer, a product that has been doing very well internationally was also available for this comparison review. Each player had something unique about itself. While there were some that couldn't play all the popular formats, there were some which could stream video podcasts and some which could even download BitTorrent files to the drive. We had the task of finding which one did the most and how well. This meant we had the grueling task of playing lots and lots of high-definition movies and clips for extended periods of time.

ASUS O!Play HDP-R1

ASUS sent across two players. The first player we tested was the O!Play HDP-R1. The player sits horizontally taking up some table space but keep in mind most HD players are the size of a thick diary. As a player that will hardly see rough use, it's built well. There are TV and Ethernet ports at the back of the player and USB ports on

its side. One of the two ports can also be used as an eSATA port. The body has a plain matte finish and a glossy front with the indicators. It looks like a fancy set top box.

The remote is somewhat fat and larger than some of the other players, but more comfortable to hold than some of the small, thin remotes. The buttons are pretty large as well. The playback buttons could have been as large as the directional buttons. Placement isn't ideal either the playback buttons lie at the top and the volume buttons at the left bottom of the remote. The remote has a good range as well, but you need to point at the player for it to work well.

The interface is designed well. It's very responsive. There's little load time for movies and device startup times are also equally low at just under ten seconds. Videos ran fine and there was little to complain about the quality. We faced some problems with certain standard resolution FLV files where as high-definition ones worked just fine.

ASUS O!Play HDP-R3

The O!Play HDP-R3 model is almost identical to the HDP-R1 in almost all aspects. The user interfaces and the products look the same. There are a couple of things that make it different - there is a memory card reader on one side of the player but the

same USB and eSATA ports on the other as the R3.

The only problem we faced with some of these products was the inability to manually enter an IP address or PC name to access shares if they don't show up automatically in the list of network devices. We had problems running media over

to be one of the smaller players you can buy. It comes with an HDMI port, 2 USB ports and composite connectors for audio and video. It's built well and you could even hide it near your TV if you wanted to. Being the first of its kind, it came with no Wi-Fi or even a wired network connection.

The interface is pretty - it has lots of simple icons with a very basic colour scheme to it and is still one of the nicer interfaces. The remote is extremely simple to use. It's small and maybe a little too small for some. There are no volume level controls on the remote which makes things a little more difficult. You have to run to your TV or audio system remote.

You can have music playing in the background while you browse through all the other folders for more music, videos or photos. Video quality appears somewhat harsher and grainier. Fast forwarding doesn't seem to be effective with

the wireless network setup, as was expected on most wireless networks. There are no antenna provisions made available either. The problems were present even with the player kept some three feet from the router. Using the wireless functionality is not recommended in general if you're thinking of streaming 720p or 1080p content over the network on 802.11g networks. We faced similar problems with the formats as we did on the HDP-R1 model especially with standard FLV formats. All the other formats played flawlessly.

WD HD TV Player

The WD HD Player was one of the HD players to first arrive in the market and it was a phenomenon then. It was one of the most versatile and reliable players to get the job done. The WD HD player continues

all formats. The speed of fast forwarding isn't constant.

The FLV sample gave us some problem playing. Otherwise, it'd be a perfect HD player for a family that requires no network support, just a cheap dependable HD player. If lack of FLV support doesn't bother you so much, this is a good player to consider.



ASUS O!Play HDP-R3



WD HD TV Player



ASUS O!Play HDP-R1